were pleased that some Soviet Jews were being allowed to leave the Soviet Union, but felt more should be allowed to emigrate. As he had at Geneva and Reykjavik, Gorbachev bristled when he heard the translation of my remarks on Soviet human rights abuses.

He replied that he was not the accused standing in a dock and I was not a prosecutor, and that I had no right to bring up domestic matters of the Soviet Union. In fact, he said, a proposal then current in Washington to build a fence along the Mexican border was as bad as anything the Soviets had ever done.

I replied that the fence was meant to stop illegal immigration by people who wanted to join our society because it offered democratic and economic opportunities—that was hardly the same thing as building the Berlin Wall, which imprisoned people in a social system they didn't want to be part of.

"Americans have fewer human rights than the Soviet people," Gorbachev persisted. "What about your people who sleep in the streets and all your unemployed? Where are their human rights?"

"Yes," I said, "but are you aware that we have something in this country called unemployment insurance, that when a man loses his job, for a certain period of time he continues to receive payment?"

Gorbachev asked:

"What happens when he comes to the end of that period and still doesn't have a job?"

"Well," I said, "then we have another program. We call it welfare. They become eligible for that if they still can't get a job."

He'd never heard of unemployment or welfare benefits before.

We didn't come to any agreement on this issue, but I enjoyed the debate and I think he did, too. We agreed to